A Complete Small Group Study Resource

Jude 5–11

Three Warnings from History: When Grace Is Misused

Small Group Bible Study Series · Jude

Source: The Gospel Vault
Editor: The Gospel Vault

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Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NASB · Jude 5–11

5 *Now I desire to remind you, though you know all things once for all, that the Lord, after saving a people out of the land of Egypt, subsequently destroyed those who did not believe.*

6 *And angels who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper abode, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness for the judgment of the great day,*

7 *just as Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them, since they in the same way as these indulged in gross immorality and went after strange flesh, are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire.*

8 *Yet in the same way these men, also by dreaming, defile the flesh, and reject authority, and revile angelic majesties.*

9 *But Michael the archangel, when he disputed with the devil and argued about the body of Moses, did not dare pronounce against him a railing judgment, but said, "The Lord rebuke you!"*

10 *But these men revile the things which they do not understand; and the things which they know by instinct, like unreasoning animals, by these things they are destroyed.*

11 *Woe to them! For they have gone the way of Cain, and for pay they have rushed headlong into the error of Balaam, and perished in the rebellion of Korah.*

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② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

> *"Now I desire to remind you, though you know all things once for all, that the Lord, after saving a people out of the land of Egypt, subsequently destroyed those who did not believe."*

History is a teacher, and Jude says it is always in session. The three examples he gives are not ancient curiosities. They are mirrors. A people rescued from Egypt who lost the inheritance through unbelief. Angels who left the place God gave them. Cities that lit up a landscape as a warning for centuries.

Then he names three people — Cain, Balaam, Korah — whom the church has needed to recognize in every generation: worship on our own terms, ministry for profit, and leadership that resists God's appointed order. These patterns are not new, and neither is what follows them.

But notice what Jude does not tell the kept to do: be afraid. He tells them to remember. The God who judged these patterns also preserved Noah, Lot, Caleb, and Joshua. The same consistency that makes His judgment sure makes His keeping sure.

Reflect

1. Which of the three patterns — Cain, Balaam, or Korah — is hardest for you to spot in practice?
2. What difference does it make that the wilderness generation was redeemed and still lost the inheritance?
3. Where do you most need the reminder that the God who judges consistently also keeps consistently?

The Judge is consistent. So is the Keeper.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

> **Proposition.** Jude proves from three historical judgments, and from three Old Testament figures, that God has always answered the abuse of His grace — and that those who are kept need not fear what falls on those who walk that road.

Introduction — The God Who Has Done This Before

When Jude wants to show how serious the threat of verses 3–4 is, he does not reach for abstract arguments. He reaches into history. He says, in effect: this pattern — receiving God's grace and then abusing it — is one God has judged before, and the record is on the books.

This is a legal argument from precedent. In a courtroom, prior rulings bind future decisions. In a pastoral letter, prior acts of God show His character and establish the pattern His justice follows. Three cases (vv. 5–7) and three portraits (v. 11) make the same point: the Judge is consistent. The men inside Jude's churches are not breaking new ground. They are walking a path others have walked, and the destination is on record.

Jude assumes his readers know these stories: "though you know all things once for all." Our task is to refresh them. When we do, we find that these are not dusty accounts. They are mirrors held up to every generation.

I. Three Warnings from History – vv. 5–7

A. The wilderness generation: saved, then destroyed – v. 5

Jude opens with the most arresting case. These are the people God Himself brought out of Egypt: they saw the plagues, walked through the sea on dry ground, ate manna, and drank water from the rock. Paul says that rock was Christ (1 Corinthians 10:1–4). If any generation had reason to trust God, this one did. Yet "the Lord, after saving a people out of the land of Egypt, subsequently destroyed those who did not believe."

Numbers 13–14 tells how. The spies came back, ten of them frightened, and the people believed the obstacles more than the God who had split the sea. God sentenced that generation to die in the wilderness without entering the land. The word "destroyed" is a decisive act of judgment — real, and physical.

Here Free Grace and Reformed readers part ways again. The Reformed reading — Schreiner and Caneday in *The Race Set Before Us* — treats the wilderness generation as a warning that those who fall short of persevering faith can lose salvation.[1] The Free Grace reading notes what the text says: these people were saved out of Egypt, and what they lost was the *inheritance*, the land and the rest God had set before them. Hebrews 3–4 draws the same lesson for believers: the danger is missing the rest, not losing the redemption.[2] The question the letter raises is not "Will I lose my salvation?" but "Will I enter into what my salvation was meant to give?"

A soldier on the winning side holds his citizenship securely. He can still be court-martialed for conduct unbecoming and lose his rank and benefits without losing his citizenship. The

wilderness generation is something like that soldier. Their place in the covenant was not undone. Their inheritance within it was forfeited.

Paul builds a whole argument on the same history. He reminds the Corinthians that "all" passed through the sea and all ate and drank the same spiritual food — "nevertheless, with most of them God was not well-pleased, for they were laid low in the wilderness" (1 Corinthians 10:1–5). Then comes the application: "these things happened as examples for us… Therefore let him who thinks he stands take heed that he does not fall" (vv. 6, 11–12). Hebrews 3:16–19 draws the same lesson: they could not enter because of unbelief. Nobody who reads Jude in this light needs to be frightened about his standing; he needs to be sober about his steps.

B. The angels who left their domain – v. 6

The second case moves from earth to the unseen world: angels "who did not keep their own domain, but abandoned their proper abode." The background is debated; many connect it to Genesis 6:1–4 and to Jewish tradition that grew from that passage. The details are disputed. The point is not. These angels had a domain and an abode. They knew their proper place and left it.

What Jude draws from it is the word "keep." The angels did not *keep* (*tēreō*) their own domain, and God now *has kept* (*tetērēken*) them in eternal bonds under darkness. It is the same word he used in verse 1: believers are "kept for Jesus Christ." The word carries both the blessing of divine preservation and the weight of divine confinement, depending on whose keeping you are in. God's keeping is never neutral; it is purposeful, and it is aimed at an outcome.

The application to the intruders is direct. They also have abandoned their proper domain. They were given grace and turned it into license. They were given a place in the community and used it for infiltration. They did not stay within the apostolic deposit of verse 3.

Readers who know 2 Peter will notice how closely Jude's examples run alongside Peter's: the angels who sinned, Sodom and Gomorrah (2 Peter 2:4–6). Peter adds Noah and Lot — those God preserved in the middle of the judgment (2 Peter 2:5, 7–9). Jude leaves the contrast for us to supply. His readers would have known that each of these judgments was also a rescue. God carried Noah through the flood and brought Lot out of Sodom. Judgment and keeping are two sides of the same consistent character.

C. Sodom and Gomorrah: an example before our eyes – v. 7

The third case is the most familiar. Sodom and Gomorrah and the cities around them "indulged in gross immorality and went after strange flesh" and now "are exhibited as an example in undergoing the punishment of eternal fire." Unlike the wilderness generation, whose judgment took decades, and unlike the imprisoned angels, whose judgment is unseen, Sodom's was immediate, visible, and permanent. For centuries the region was a landmark. God's judgment of moral rebellion is not a threat held in reserve; it has already happened (Genesis 19).

"Strange flesh" refers to the crowd's desire to violate the visitors who were angels (Genesis 19:1–11). That makes a deliberate parallel with verse 6. The angels crossed a boundary

downward, leaving heaven for earth; the men of Sodom tried to cross one upward. Both involve creatures refusing to stay inside the order God made. Both end in judgment.

Sodom's sin is also described elsewhere in broader terms. Ezekiel says Sodom's guilt was "arrogance, abundant food and careless ease, but she did not help the poor and needy" (Ezekiel 16:49), before they "committed abominations." The picture is of a people so comfortable with their own appetites that they were no longer afraid of God and no longer moved by anyone else's need. That is the soil in which license grows.

II. The Pattern Applied: Dreamers, Defilers, and Railers – vv. 8–10

A. "In the same way these men" – v. 8

With one phrase — "in the same way" — Jude turns from the past to the present. The intruders follow the same pattern. They are "dreaming." The word describes people whose direction comes from their own inner experience, their visions and intuitions, rather than from the apostolic message already delivered. That is the root of their error: they have substituted self for Scripture.

Three behaviors follow. They "defile the flesh" — the licentiousness of verse 4, now shown as a habit. They "reject authority" — they will not submit to anything outside their own experience. They "revile angelic majesties" — they speak contemptuously of spiritual realities they do not understand.

B. Michael and the devil – v. 9

Jude's contrast is devastating. Michael, the archangel, "when he disputed with the devil and argued about the body of Moses, did not dare pronounce against him a railing judgment, but said, 'The Lord rebuke you!'" The Old Testament does not record this scene, but Jude's readers evidently knew it, and Zechariah 3:2 gives the same words in a similar confrontation. Whatever the source, the point is plain. Michael had every reason to speak harshly, and he handed the verdict to the Lord.

This is also a lesson for the believer who contends for the faith. "Contend earnestly" (v. 3) is not permission for railing, contempt, or personal attack. Authority over an adversary belongs to God. "The Lord rebuke you" is a complete sentence.

Michael is no minor figure. Daniel calls him "one of the chief princes" and the great prince who stands guard over God's people (Daniel 10:13, 21; 12:1), and Revelation 12:7 shows him leading angelic armies. If any created being could trade insults with the devil, it is the one who defeats him. Yet his restraint is complete. That sets the standard for everyone else. If Michael will not rail at the devil, we should be slow to rail at anyone.

C. Reviling what they do not understand – v. 10

Verse 10 sums up their condition: they "revile the things which they do not understand," and the things they do understand, "by instinct, like unreasoning animals," are what destroy them. They are driven by appetite without reason or restraint. People who pronounce on what they do not know, and live by what they cannot help wanting, are headed where verses 5–7 end.

III. Three Portraits: The Way of Cain, the Error of Balaam, the Rebellion of Korah – v. 11

Verse 11 arrives like a verdict: “Woe to them!” It is the language of the prophets. And Jude names three figures from Israel’s history who sum up the most recurring forms of false religion.

1. The way of Cain — worship on his own terms

Cain was a worshiper. He brought an offering. His problem was not that he ignored God but that he approached God on his own terms rather than on God’s (Genesis 4:3–7; Hebrews 11:4). The false teacher in Cain’s way offers what seems spiritually fitting to him and calls it the gospel.

What makes Cain’s story so searching is that God spoke to him first. Before the murder God asked why he was angry and told him that if he did well he would be accepted, and that sin was crouching at the door (Genesis 4:6–7). Grace was offered even to Cain. John later says Cain “was of the evil one” and murdered his brother because his own deeds were evil and his brother’s were righteous (1 John 3:12). The way of Cain is the road of someone who has been told the way and chooses his own.

2. The error of Balaam — ministry for pay

Balaam could not curse what God had blessed, but he found another way. He taught Moab how to bring Israel down from within, and he did it for money (Numbers 22–24; 31:16; 2 Peter 2:15). “Rushed headlong” (*exechythēsan*) pictures someone pouring himself out toward the reward. The false teacher in Balaam’s error uses spiritual credibility for personal gain.

3. The rebellion of Korah — resisting God’s appointed order

Korah’s argument in Numbers 16:3 sounds like a defense of the people: “all the congregation is holy.” It was true, and it was beside the point. God had appointed specific leaders, and to resist them was to resist Him. The ground opened. Korah’s pattern is the one that dresses rebellion against God-given order in the language of the common good.

Notice what all three share. Cain brought an offering, Balaam was a prophet, Korah was a Levite. They were insiders. The danger of false teaching is not that it comes from outside the church but that it handles the things of God while redirecting them to its own ends.

Conclusion

Jude’s three cases and three portraits add up to one verdict: this is not new, and it does not end well. Every time, grace received and abused, boundaries crossed, and God’s judgment arrived with consistency.

But notice what Jude does not say. He does not say: therefore despair. He says: therefore remember. The God who judged the wilderness generation also brought Caleb and Joshua into the land. The God who bound the angels also preserved Noah through the flood. The God who destroyed Sodom pulled Lot out before the fire fell (2 Peter 2:4–9). He is as consistent in His keeping as He is in His judgment.

The congregation that walks through Jude's warnings is the kept community of verse 1. These examples are evidence of what God does with what deserves judgment. They are not a forecast of what He will do with those He has promised to keep.

Lord, You are consistent. Keep us.

Sources and Notes

1. Reformed reading of the wilderness generation and the warnings: Thomas R. Schreiner and Ardel B. Caneday, *The Race Set Before Us: A Biblical Theology of Perseverance and Assurance* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2001); on Hebrews 3–4, see the extended discussion there.

2. Free Grace reading — salvation versus inheritance and rewards: Zane C. Hodges, *Grace in Eclipse: A Study on Eternal Rewards*, 2nd ed. (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2007); Joseph C. Dillow, *The Reign of the Servant Kings* (Hayesville, NC: Schoettle, 1992); Robert N. Wilkin, ed., *The Grace New Testament Commentary* (Denton, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 2010), on Jude and on Hebrews 3–4.

3. Textual note: some early manuscripts read "Jesus" rather than "the Lord" in v. 5; either way the point of the verse is the same. See the NET Bible translators' notes on Jude 5.

4. Word studies: Blue Letter Bible lexicon entries G622 (*apollymi*), G5083 (*tēreō*), G746 (*archē*), G3613 (*oikētērion*), G1608 (*ekporneuō*), G1164 (*deigma*), G1797 (*enypniazomai*), G988 (*blasphēmia*), G1632 (*ekcheō*), G485 (*antilogia*); BDAG, 3rd ed.; Thomas L. Constable, *Expository Notes on Jude*, planobiblechapel.org/tcon/notes/.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.5	**ὑπομνῆσαι** to remind	G5279 hypomnēsai Aor. Act. Inf.	STR: to remind. Significance: his readers already know these stories. Their danger is forgetting under pressure, not ignorance.
v.5	**ἀπώλεσεν** destroyed	G622 apōlesen Aor. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to destroy, ruin. Significance: decisive, completed judgment. The wilderness generation was destroyed physically; their redemption from Egypt was not reversed.
v.5	**πιστεύσαντας** believed	G4100 pisteusantas Aor. Act. Ptc. Acc. Pl. Masc.	STR: to believe, trust. Significance: the failure was unbelief about God's promise of the land (Num. 14:11; Heb. 3:19).
v.6	**ἀρχήν** domain	G746 archēn N-Acc. Sg. Fem.	STR: beginning; rule, domain. Significance: the angels' assigned sphere of existence and authority, which they abandoned.
v.6	**τετήρηκεν** has kept	G5083 tetērēken Perf. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg.	STR: to guard, keep. Significance: same root as vv. 1, 13, 21. God's keeping is purposeful: for glory (v. 1) or for judgment (v. 6).
v.6	**οἰκητήριον** abode	G3613 oikētērion N-Acc. Sg. Neut.	STR: a dwelling place. Significance: the "proper abode" — the place God assigned. They left it.
v.7	**ἐκπορνεύσασαι** indulged in gross immorality	G1608 ekporneusasai Aor. Act. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Fem.	STR: to be utterly unchaste. Significance: intensified form — flagrant, unrestrained immorality.
v.7	**δεῖγμα** example	G1164 deigma N-Acc. Sg. Neut.	STR: a specimen, example. Significance: Sodom's ruin is on display as evidence of what God does with this pattern.
v.8	**ἐνυπνιαζόμενοι** dreaming	G1797 enypniazomenoi Pres. Mid. Ptc. Nom. Pl. Masc.	STR: to dream. Significance: ongoing — led by their own inner experience instead of by revealed truth. The root of all three errors.
v.9	**βλασφημίας** railing, reviling	G988 blasphēmias N-Gen. Sg. Fem.	STR: slander, vilification. Significance: Michael would not even pronounce this against the devil. The intruders pronounce it against what they do not know.
v.11	**ἐξεχύθησαν** rushed headlong	G1632 exechythēsan Aor. Pass. Ind. 3rd Pl.	STR: to pour out. Significance: "poured themselves out" toward gain — the zeal of Balaam for pay.
v.11	**ἀντιλογίᾳ** rebellion	G485 antilogia	STR: contradiction, dispute. Significance: Korah's "speaking against" the order God had appointed (Num.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
		N-Dat. Sg. Fem.	16).

Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
What do the three examples in vv. 5–7 have in common?	Each shows creatures receiving a place from God and abusing it, and each ends in judgment. Together they make a legal argument from precedent.
In what sense was the wilderness generation "saved," and what did they lose?	They were saved out of Egypt and under God's provision, but through unbelief lost the land and rest He had set before them. The text says "destroyed," not that their redemption was undone.
What does the word "keep" (*tēreō*) do in v. 6?	It connects to v. 1: believers are kept for Christ; the angels who did not keep their domain are kept in bonds for judgment. God's keeping is purposeful, for glory or for judgment.
Why does Jude cite Michael's restraint in v. 9?	To contrast the archangel's deference to the Lord, even against the devil, with the intruders' reviling of what they do not understand.
What does each of the three figures in v. 11 represent?	Cain: approaching God on one's own terms. Balaam: using ministry for pay. Korah: resisting God's appointed order under the banner of the common good.
What do Cain, Balaam, and Korah have in common that makes them good warnings?	All were insiders who handled the things of God. The danger is internal, not only external.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. The wilderness generation lost the inheritance but not the redemption. How does that distinction shape how we read warnings in Scripture?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.A — Numbers 13–14; Hebrews 3–4; the Free Grace and Reformed readings.*

2. In what ways might the "keeping" of v. 6 and the "keeping" of v. 1 differ — and how are they alike?

> *Leader note: See Commentary I.B — tēreō as purposeful keeping.*

3. Why does Jude contrast the intruders with Michael? What does it teach about how to contend?

> *Leader note: See Commentary II.B — "The Lord rebuke you."*

4. Which of the three patterns — Cain, Balaam, Korah — do you most need to watch for in your own heart?

> *Leader note: See Commentary III.*

5. Jude says “therefore remember.” What does it do for you to remember that God also preserved Noah, Lot, Caleb, and Joshua?

> *Leader note: See Commentary Conclusion; 2 Peter 2:4–9.*

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
v. 5	Wilderness generation	Redeemed, yet lost the inheritance through unbelief.
v. 6	Fallen angels	They left their domain and are now kept in bonds. God’s keeping is purposeful.
v. 7	Sodom and Gomorrah	Moral rebellion against God’s order is judged — and the ruin stands as an example.
vv. 8–10	The intruders	Dreaming, defiling, authority-rejecting, reviling what they do not know.
v. 11	Cain, Balaam, Korah	Three insider patterns: self-directed worship, ministry for pay, resisted authority.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

Application 1 — Remember the Record

Jude 5

Drawn from Commentary Introduction and I. Key term: hypomnēsai (to remind).

Jude's first word before the examples is "remind." His readers already knew these stories. In crisis, what we know recedes and what we feel advances. His answer is not new information but recovered memory of what God has done and who He is.

Reflection: Which of the three examples speaks most directly to what you see in the church today?

Practical Step: Read Numbers 14:1–23 this week. Note what the people failed to trust God for.

Application 2 — Know the Three Patterns

Jude 11

Drawn from Commentary III. Key terms: misthos (pay), antilogia (rebellion).

Cain, Balaam, and Korah give a way to recognize false teaching by its pattern, not by its label. Teaching that approaches God on its own terms, ministry that trades on credibility for gain, and leadership that resists God-given order in the name of the people: each is on record.

Reflection: Which of these patterns is easiest for you to excuse in a teacher you like?

Practical Step: Read the account of Korah in Numbers 16:1–35. Write one sentence on how his argument sounds today.

Application 3 — Let Restraint Be Part of Your Contending

Jude 9

Drawn from Commentary II.B. Key term: blasphēmias (railing).

Michael's restraint is the most under-preached moment in Jude. Contending for the faith is not licence for contempt. "The Lord rebuke you" hands the verdict to the One who has the right to give it.

Reflection: When you respond to error, are you speaking from your authority or deferring to the Lord's?

Practical Step: The next time you feel the pull to answer sharply, pause and ask: am I about to rail, or am I contending?

Application 4 — The Kept Are Not Walking Toward These Woes

Jude 1; 5–7; 11

Drawn from Commentary Conclusion. Cf. 2 Peter 2:4–9; FGR: Hodges, Grace in Eclipse.

The examples are addressed to the intruders. They show what God does with what deserves judgment. They do not threaten what He has promised to keep. Caleb and Joshua entered the land; Noah was carried through the flood; Lot was pulled from Sodom.

Reflection: Do you read the warnings of Scripture as threats to your standing, or as evidence of God's consistent character?

Practical Step: Write one sentence that holds both truths: what God does with grace abused, and what He does for those He keeps.

End of Study · Jude 5–11